The Dalai Lama was unsure about leaving Lhasa. He knew that if he left Tibet, he might never be allowed to come back. When the Chinese started bombing the walls of the Norbulingka, the Dalai Lama finally knew it was time. He consulted a book filled with the teachings of Buddha. The page he read was about having courage. He thought about the courage he would need on the journey ahead.

When evening came, the Dalai Lama changed out of his monk's robes and dressed as a Tibetan soldier. He said goodbye to the people at the palace, including Ponpo, who had been with him since he first came to Lhasa almost twenty years earlier.

Late in the evening, he and others dressed as soldiers left through one of the Norbulingka's gates and made their way through the crowd. No one recognized him. They crossed the Kyichu River in yak-skin boats. On the other side, they met the rest of their group, about one hundred in all, including government officials, his mother, and other members of his family.



They set off on horses, riding as fast as they could without stopping. It was freezing, windy, and dusty. By morning, they reached the Che-La mountain pass. At the top of the steep slope, the Dalai Lama looked back at Lhasa one last time.